Topic 29 — Indian Environmental Movements

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Chipko (चिपको) | Appiko (अप्पिको) | Silent Valley (साइलेंट वैली) | Narmada (नर्मदा) Bachao (नर्मदा बचाओ) Andolan (नर्मदा बचाओ) | Bishnoi (बिश्नोई) | Jungle Bachao Andolan | Save Western Ghats (पश्चिमी घाट)

Sources baked in: NCERT Bio/Geo; Gadgil 2011; Kasturirangan 2013; UPPCS/UPSC PYQs **Weight:** ★★★ High — movement ↔ state/year/leader matching **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs (this topic)

- Movement years and states are fixed history (इतिहास); CA rarely renames Chipko / Appiko / NBA.
- Keep NBA (Andolan) ≠ National Biodiversity Authority acronym trap ready.

29.1 Chipko Movement (चिपको आंदोलन)

Identity: 1973 | Reni, Uttarakhand | Tree hugging | Bahuguna, Bhatt, Gaura Devi

Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Commercial logging threatened village forests, soil, and water security in Garhwal hills.

Course: Chipko began in **March 1973** at **Reni, Chamoli (चमोली)** (then UP, now Uttarakhand). Villagers hugged trees to stop contractors. On **26 March 1974**, **Gaura Devi** led women who blocked ash-tree felling. Leaders include **Sunderlal Bahuguna**, **Chandi Prasad Bhatt** (चंडी प्रसाद भट्ट), and **Gaura Devi**. Method = non-violent passive resistance (निष्क्रिय प्रतिरोध).

Result: National symbol of community forest protection. Influenced the conservation tilt behind **Forest (Conservation) Act 1980** and **National Forest Policy 1988**. Bahuguna's line — "ecology is permanent economy" — entered coaching memory.

- **Maiti Movement** (मैती आंदोलन) (Uttarakhand; pioneered by **Kalyan Singh Rawat**, mid-1990s) asks newly married couples to plant a sapling at the bride's parental home — separate from Chipko.
- Related movements: **Appiko** (अप्पिको) (Karnataka), **Narmada Bachao Andolan** (anti-large dam on Narmada).

Logic: Chipko = **Uttarakhand 1973**, not Karnataka (Appiko) or Kerala (Silent Valley).

29.2 Appiko Movement

Identity: 1983 | Karnataka | Panduranga Hegde | Southern Chipko

Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Commercial clear-felling and monoculture plantations threatened Western Ghats watersheds and local livelihoods in **Uttara Kannada**.

Course: Appiko (“to embrace” in **Kannada**) launched in **1983** at **Sirsi / Kalase**, Karnataka. **Panduranga Hegde** led tree-embrace protests for sustainable forestry. The fight protected high-rainfall catchments of the **Kali** (काली), **Aghanashini**, and **Sharavathi**.

Result: Became the southern tree-embrace counterpart of Chipko. It remains a **Karnataka-only** state trap and is **not** the same campaign as Save Western Ghats (2011+ report politics).

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q122

Appiko Movement is associated with: (1) Uttarakhand (2) Uttar Pradesh (3) Kerala (4) Karnataka

Options: A. 1 and 2 B. Only 4 C. 3 and 4 D. Only 1

Show answer

Logic: Appiko ≠ Chipko state. Answer is **only Karnataka**. **Ans: B.** **Karnataka only**. UK/UP = Chipko geography; Kerala = Silent Valley.

29.3 Silent Valley Movement

Identity: 1970s–83 | Kerala | Anti-hydro dam | KSSP | SVNP 1984

Cause, Course, Result

Cause: A Kerala State Electricity Board hydro project on the **Kunthipuzha** threatened to submerge **Silent Valley** (साइलेंट वैली) tropical evergreen rainforest in **Palakkad**.

Course: Peak mobilisation ran **1978–1983**. **Kerala Sastra Sahitya (साहित्य) Parishad (KSSP)** and scientists led petitions, media, and science-based advocacy — not primarily tree-hugging. Pressure reached the Centre.

Result: Indira Gandhi (गांधी) declared protection in **1983**. **Silent Valley National Park** was notified in **1984** and later included in the **Nilgiri (नीलगिरि) Biosphere Reserve (जैवमंडल आरक्षित क्षेत्र)**. The case stands as India’s classic anti-dam rainforest save — different from Chipko/Appiko anti-logging.

> **Logic:** Silent Valley = **Kerala**, not Tamil Nadu.

29.4 Narmada Bachao Andolan

Identity: 1985+ | Medha Patkar | Sardar Sarovar (सरदार सरोवर) | MP–Gujarat–Maharashtra

Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Large dams on the **Narmada**, especially **Sardar Sarovar** (सरदार सरोवर), threatened mass displacement of adivasi (आदिवासी) and peasant communities with weak rehabilitation and river-ecology loss.

Course: The movement formalised around **1985**. Leaders include **Medha Patkar** and **Baba Amte**. Methods mixed satyagraha (सत्याग्रह), jal yatras, court petitions, and drowning protests (jalsamarpan). **World Bank withdrew** funding in **1993** after NBA pressure. Supreme Court rulings (**2000**, **2005**) balanced construction with R&R conditions.

Result: Raised national rehabilitation standards and made displacement a permanent large-dam debate. The project continued under court conditions; the movement's lasting mark is the **R&R + ecology** frame, not a total dam stop.

> **Logic:** In movement questions, **NBA = Narmada Bachao Andolan** — not National Biodiversity Authority (Chennai).

29.5 Bishnoi Movement

Identity: 1730 | Khejarli, Rajasthan | Amrita Devi | 363 martyrs | Khejri trees

Cause, Course, Result

Cause: **Maharaja (महाराज) Abhay Singh** ordered felling of **khejri** trees near **Khejarli (Jodhpur)** for kiln fuel, hitting Bishnoi sacred ecology.

Course: In **September 1730**, **Amrita Devi** and villagers hugged trees; **363 Bishnois** were martyred defending them. The **Bishnoi sect** (founded by **Guru (गुरु) Jambheshwar, 1485**) already taught flora (वनस्पति)–fauna (प्राणीजात) protection (blackbuck, chinkara) among its **29** principles.

Result: The Maharaja later banned tree felling in Bishnoi villages. The episode is the oldest syllabus forest-protection memory and a conceptual precursor to Chipko — different century and desert ecology.

> **Logic:** Bishnoi = **1730 Rajasthan**, not 1973 Uttarakhand.

29.6 Jungle Bachao Andolan

Identity: 1982 | Singhbhum, Jharkhand | Tribal forest resistance

Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Commercial forest exploitation and plantation policies in **Singhbhum** threatened customary forest rights of adivasi communities.

Course: Around **1982**, tribal resistance in Singhbhum (then Bihar, now **Jharkhand**) opposed contractor timber interests and state plantation frames that displaced forest-dependent people.

Result: Became part of broader Jharkhand tribal ecology politics — distinct from Himalayan Chipko or Kerala Silent Valley.

> **Logic:** Jungle Bachao = **Singhbhum/Jharkhand**, not Garhwal or Karnataka.

29.7 Save Western Ghats Movement

Identity: 2011+ | Multi-state | Gadgil 2011 | Kasturirangan 2013 | ESZ/mining politics

Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Mining, hydropower, and infrastructure pressure on the **Western Ghats** (पश्चिमी घाट) biodiversity hotspot (जैव विविधता हॉटस्पॉट) across Kerala, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Goa (गोवा), and Tamil Nadu raised demands for stronger ecological zoning.

Course: The **Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel (Madhav Gadgil), 2011** recommended strong ecological sensitivity zoning. The **Kasturirangan High-Level Working Group, 2013** moderated ESA extent. Farmer, mining, and conservation protests followed ESZ and report politics.

Result: Save Western Ghats became a multi-state **policy/ecology** conflict distinct from **Appiko 1983** (local Karnataka tree-felling protest). Gadgil vs Kasturirangan remains the report-pair trap.

Report	Year	Tone
Gadgil WGEEP	**2011**	Stronger ESZ / conservation
Kasturirangan HLWG	**2013**	Narrower ESA / moderated

> **Logic:** Do not equate Appiko 1983 with Save Western Ghats 2011+.
